

MCP DEV SUMMIT SEOUL 2026

Skills and MCP: **Complementary,** Not Competing

Dale Seo · Software Engineer, Apollo GraphQL



SPEAKER

Dale Seo

Software Engineer, Apollo GraphQL

-
- Apollo MCP Server • Apollo Skills • GraphOS MCP Server
-
- Rust MCP SDK (rmcp) maintainer
-
- AAIF Workflows Working Group
-
- GraphQL AI Working Group
-

Did Skills Kill MCP?

#mcp #agents #skills #ai

MCP is dead or MCP vs Skills — revisited

4 min read · Mar 21, 2026

124 6 3

BY GEOFFREY HUNTLEY IN AI — 23 AUG 2025

too many model context protocol servers and LLM allocations on the dance floor

Have MCPs died because of Skills?

12 MARCH 2026 | [RESOURCES](#)

MCP sucks honestly

It eats too much context window and you have to toggle it on and off and the auth sucks

AGENDA

01 History

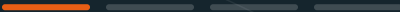
02 Differences

03 Using them together

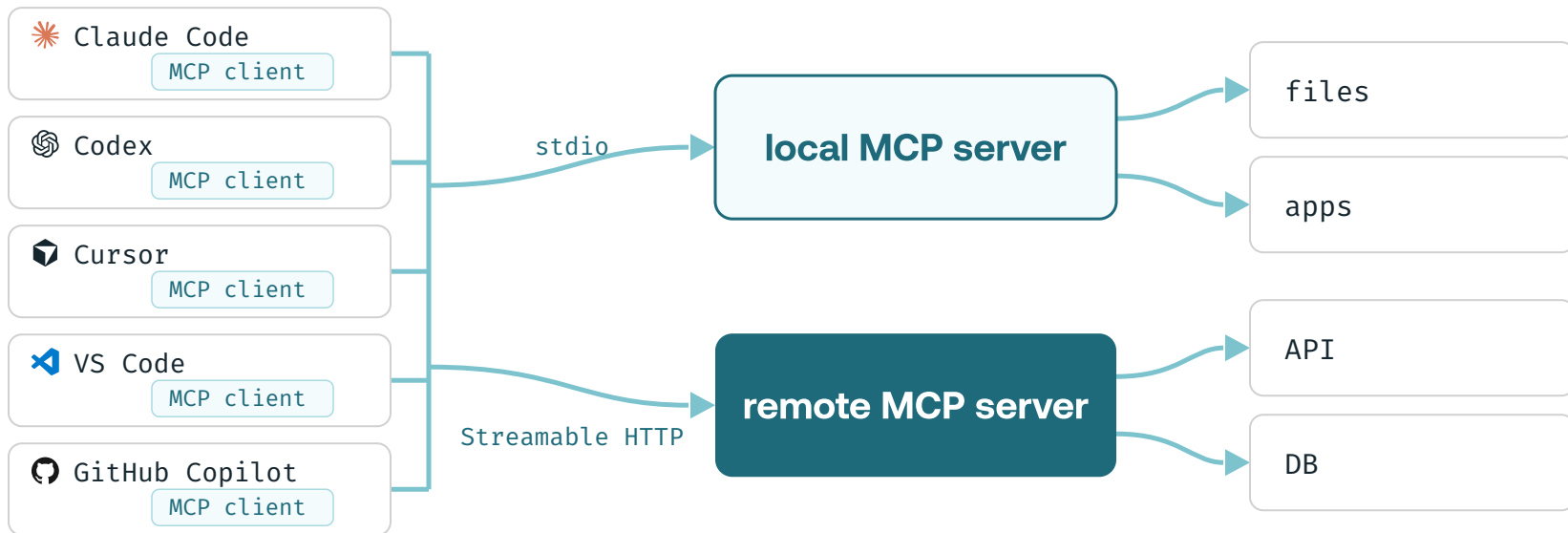
04 Lessons from shipping

PART 01

A history of two standards

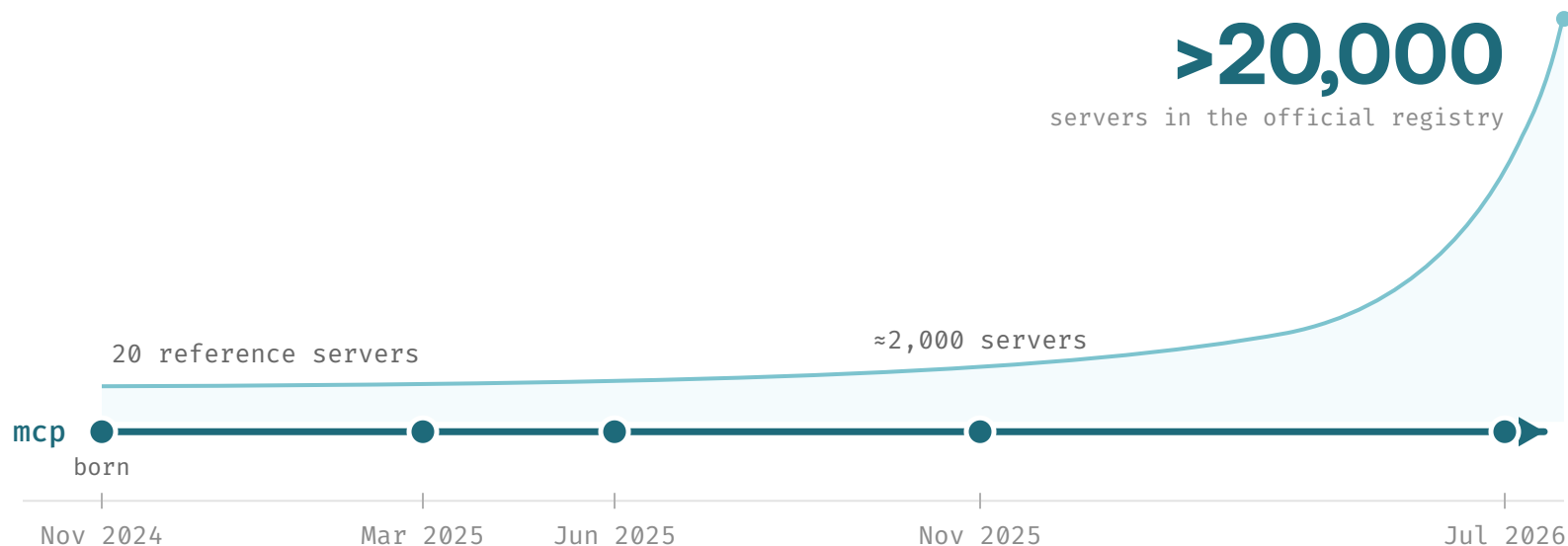


A standard way to give agents access



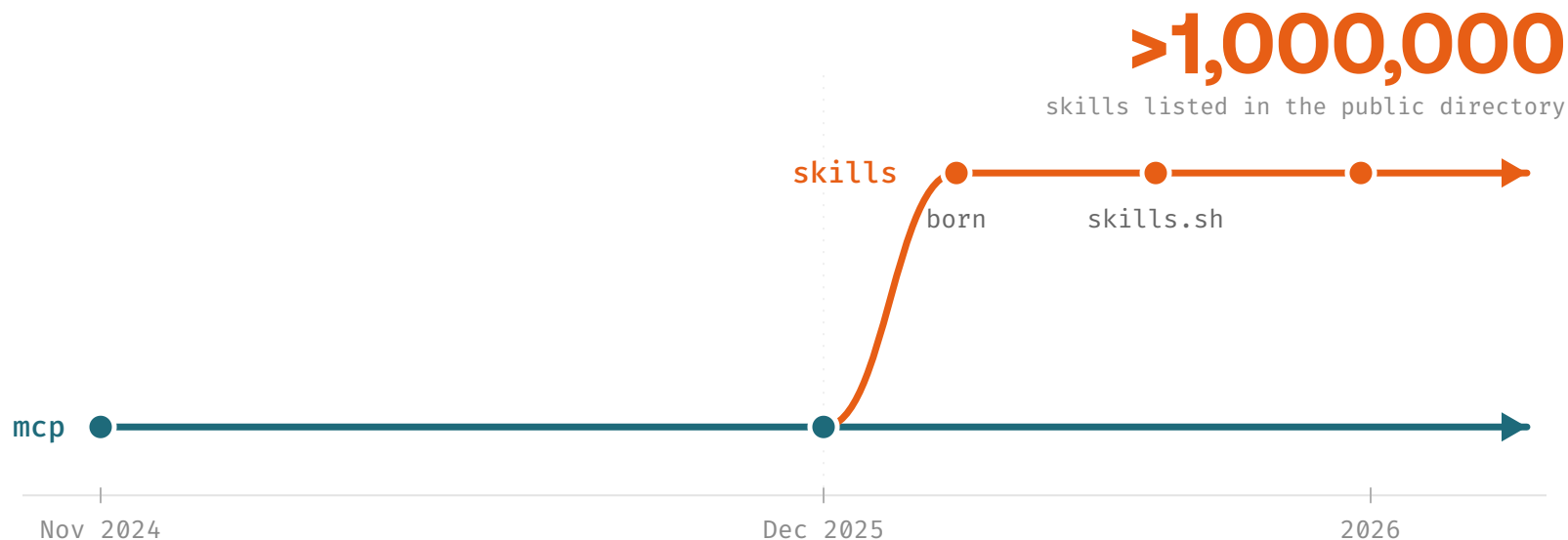
NOVEMBER 2024

The first bottleneck



DECEMBER 2025

The bottleneck shifted



It's just a folder with SKILL.md

```
my-skill/
├── SKILL.md           # required
├── references/        # optional – deep dives
│   ├── queries.md
│   ├── mutations.md
│   └── caching.md
├── scripts/          # optional – code
│   ├── run-codegen.sh
│   └── check-config.sh
└── assets/           # optional – templates
    └── provider.tsx
```

```
---
name: apollo-server
description: >
  Guide for building GraphQL servers with
  Apollo Server 5.x. Use this skill when:
  (1) setting up a new Apollo Server project,
  (2) writing resolvers or defining schemas...
license: MIT
---
```

Apollo Server 5.x Guide

Apollo Server is an open-source GraphQL server that works with any GraphQL schema...

Quick start

1. Install the packages:
`npm install @apollo/server graphql`
2. Define a schema, then pass it to a new ApolloServer instance...

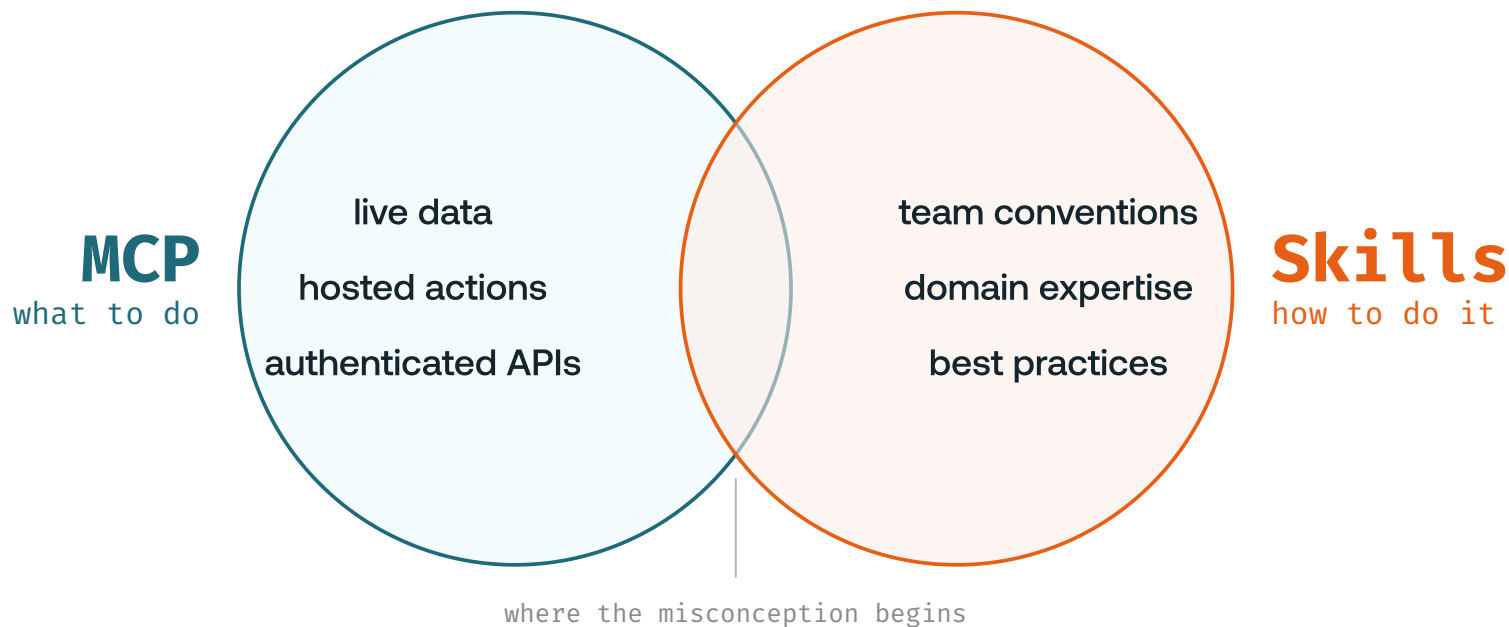
PART 02

Two jobs, one overlap



OVERLAP

Different jobs, mostly



The rate of change



TanStack Intent / Registry

Agent Skills Registry

npm packages that ship versioned Agent Skills. Install them and your AI coding agent learns your dependencies automatically.

308 packages **1161** skills **7105** versions indexed

 [Ship skills with your library and get listed here →](#)

Packages

Skills

 client

Most downloaded ▾

25 packages matching "client"

@tanstack/start-client-core

new



7 skills 73.4M/mo 9h ago

@apollo/client

new



1 skill 28.4M/mo 1d ago

A fully-featured caching GraphQL client.

@trpc/client

new



3 skills 15.5M/mo 11d ago

The tRPC client library

@electric-sql/client

new



@tanstack/db

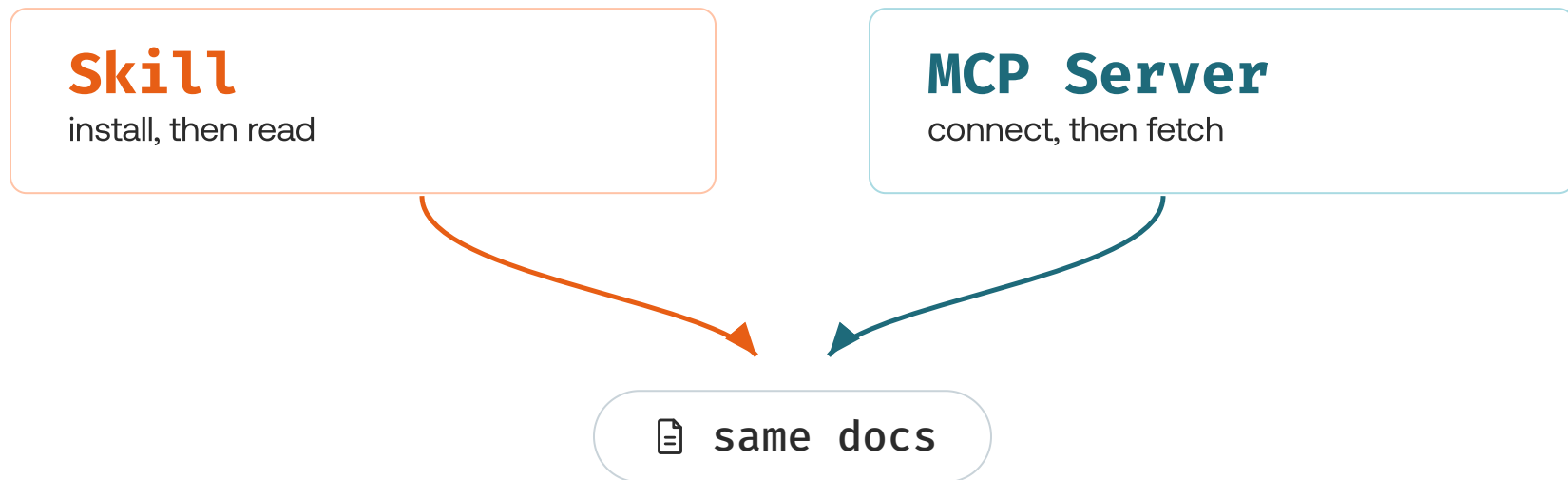
new



@durable-streams/client



two routes to the same source



Up-to-date docs for AI agents

Get the latest docs into Claude, Codex, Cursor and other agents

```
$ npx ctx7 setup
```

[Install](#)[Get API Key](#)[60.4K stars on GitHub](#)

```
> npx ctx7 setup
```

```
? How should your agent access Context7?
```

```
> MCP server
```

```
Agent calls Context7 tools via MCP protocol to retrieve up-to-date library docs
```

```
CLI + Skills
```

```
Installs a find-docs skill that guides your agent to fetch up-to-date library docs using ctx7 CLI commands
```

```
↑↓ navigate • ↵ select
```

Name	Source	Benchmark	Snippets	Update	Trust
Next.js	 /vercel/next.js	88.3	6K	4 hours	★★★★
OpenCode	 /anomalyco/opencode	82.1	3.4K	1 day	★★★★
Better Auth	 /better-auth/better-auth	87.9	5.1K	2 days	★★★★

TREND

Local MCP gives way to CLI + Skills



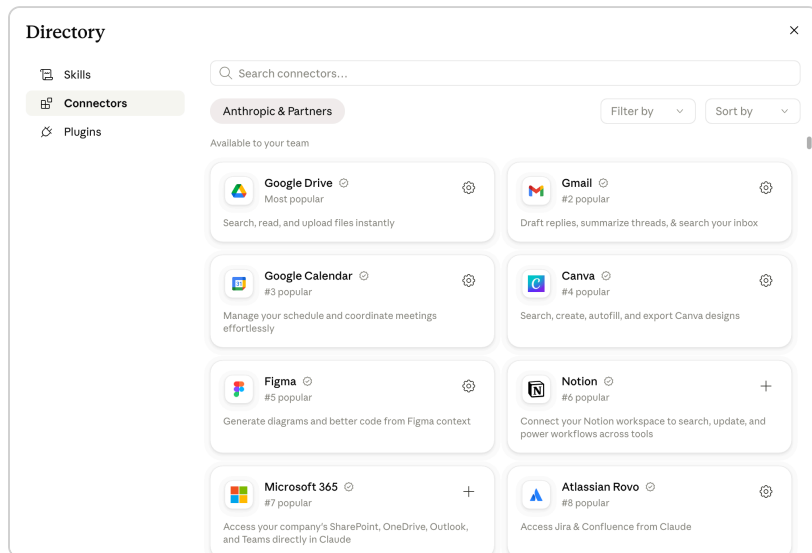
**Stdio
MCP**



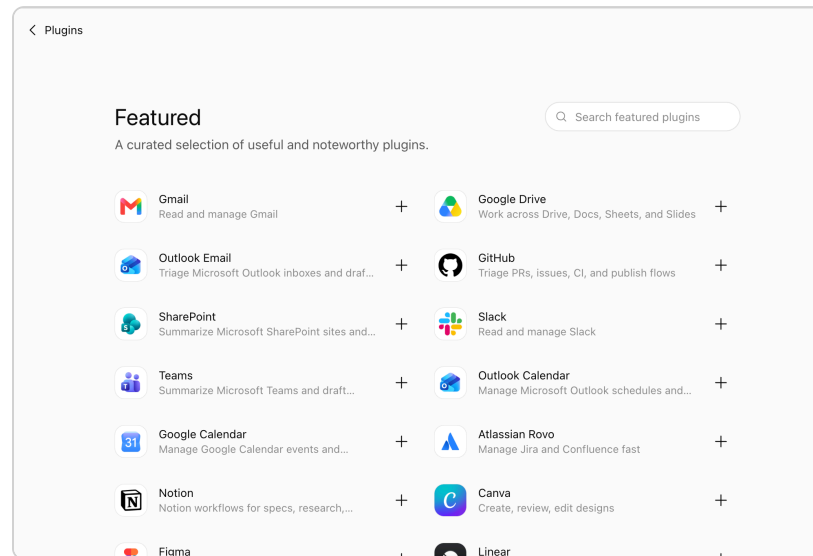
**CLI +
Skills**

Vendors converge on remote MCP

Claude



ChatGPT



Loaded on connect, or loaded on use

MCP loads on connect

```
search_orders  
create_ticket  
get_invoice  
update_status  
list_customers  
refund_order  
cancel_order  
get_shipment  
list_products  
add_note  
assign_agent  
close_ticket  
...
```

Skills loads progressively

name + description (up to 100 tokens)

SKILL.md on pickup

references on demand

SIDE BY SIDE

The weaknesses interlock

Remote MCP

brings the runtime

always fresh

infra + auth

loads up front

CLI + Skills

borrowes the runtime

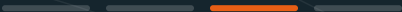
easily drift

a folder

progressive disclosure

PART 03

Using them together



The write-up nobody wants

INC-4417

router · elevated 5xx on the supergraph

10:14 – 10:55 UTC

41 min



One internal marketplace

01 add the marketplace once

```

) /plugins

Plugins Discover Installed Marketplaces Errors

) ● apollonaut-plugins
  mdg-private/apollonaut-plugins
  7 available • 3 installed • Updated 6/24/2026

● * claude-plugins-official *
  anthropics/claude-plugins-official
  280 available • 1 installed • Updated 8/7/2026

● cloudflare
  cloudflare/skills
  1 available • 1 installed • Updated 6/12/2026
  
```

02 install plugins from it

```

) /plugins

Plugins Discover Installed Marketplaces Errors

Installed plugins (3):
● apollo-arch-skills
  Golden path skills for Apollo platform engineers.
  Provides architecture auditing and feature
  planning workflows grounded in live architecture
  data from v2-arch-automation.
● engineering
  Code review, planning, commits, debugging, and
  dependency management – with auto-format, lint,
  and test hooks for Rust, Kotlin, and TypeScript.
● productivity
  Doc review, doc generation, incident reports, and
  meeting summaries – with Atlassian, Slack, Figma,
  and Google integrations.
  
```

Give the agent live access

```
/mcp

Manage MCP servers
32 servers

claude.ai
) claude.ai Atlassian · ✓ connected · 40 tools
  claude.ai Datadog · ✓ connected · 329 tools
  claude.ai Excalidraw · ✓ connected · 5 tools
  claude.ai Figma · ✓ connected · 27 tools
  claude.ai Gmail · ✓ connected · 16 tools
  claude.ai Google Calendar · ✓ connected · 9 tools
  claude.ai Google Drive · ✓ connected · 8 tools
  claude.ai Granola · ✓ connected · 6 tools
  claude.ai GraphOS MCP Tools · ✓ connected · 13 tools
  claude.ai incident.io · ✓ connected · 45 tools
  claude.ai PagerDuty · ✓ connected · 64 tools
  claude.ai Slack · ✓ connected · 13 tools
  claude.ai Zoom for Claude · ✓ connected · 12 tools
→ Show unused connectors (9)
```

```
/mcp

Claude.ai PagerDuty MCP Server

Status:                ✓ connected
URL:                    https://mcp.pagerduty.com/mcp
Config location:        claude.ai
Capabilities: tools
Tools: 64 tools

) 1. View tools
   2. Clear authentication
   3. Reconnect
   4. Disable

↑/↓ to navigate · Enter to select · Esc to back
```

Give the agent the runbook

```
/skills

Skills
33/73 skills · enter/space to cycle, / to search, t to sort, Esc to close

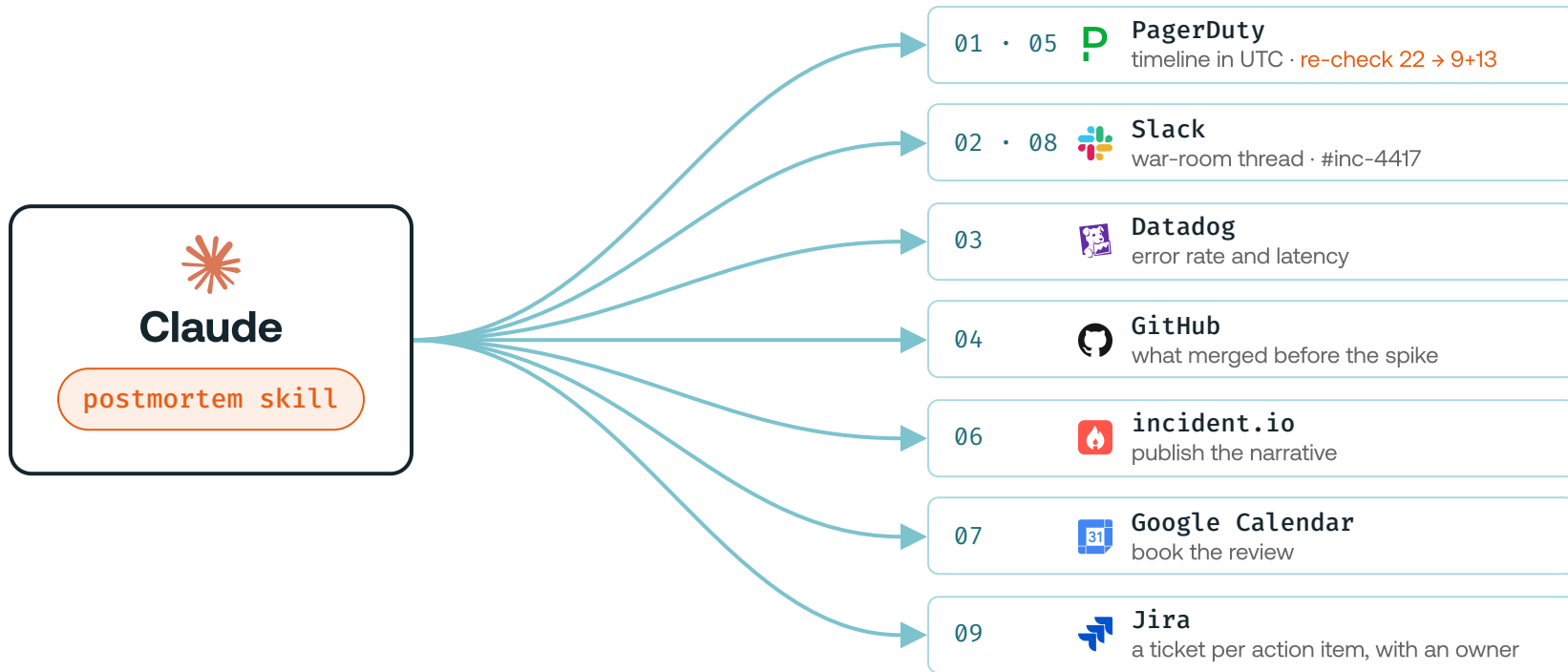
  ⚙ engineering

  🔒 on      engineering:identity · plugin · ~80 tok · locked by plugin
  🔒 on      engineering:incident-report · plugin · ~70 tok · locked by plugin
  🔒 on      engineering:jira-support-ticket-skepticism · plugin · ~170 tok · locked by plugin
  🔒 on      engineering:oncall-update · plugin · ~40 tok · locked by plugin
  🔒 on      engineering:platform-api · plugin · ~90 tok · locked by plugin
  🔒 on      engineering:postmortem · plugin · ~70 tok · locked by plugin
  🔒 on      engineering:postmortem-review · plugin · ~150 tok · locked by plugin

Plugin skills are managed via /plugin
```

ORCHESTRATION

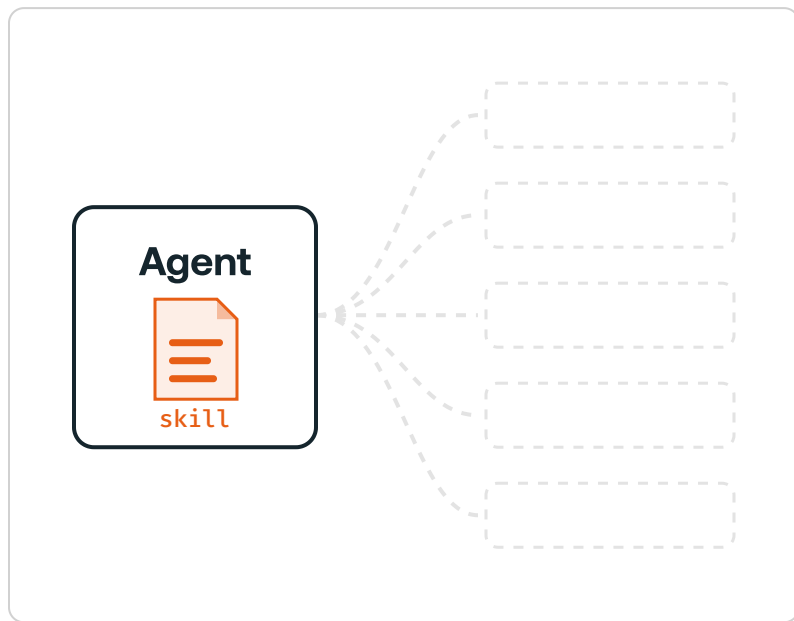
```
> "Write up last night's incident." █
```



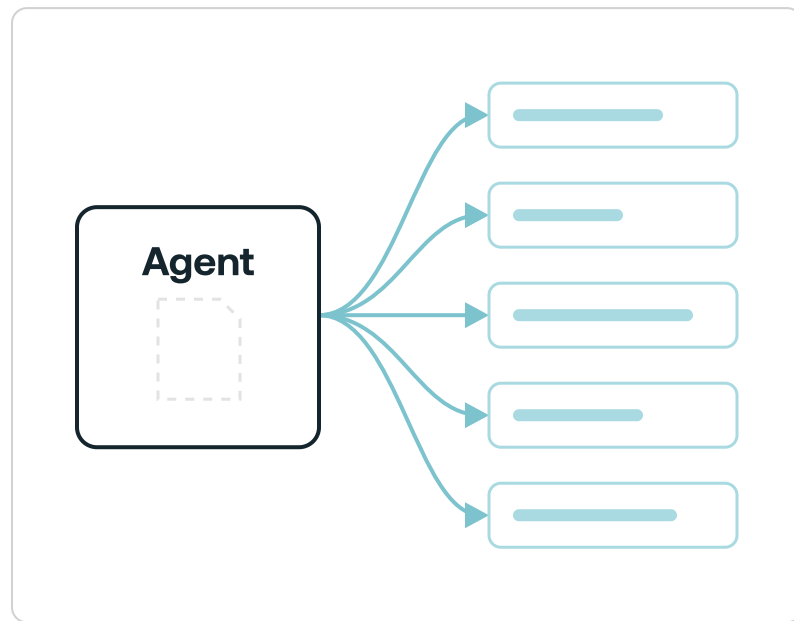
SUBTRACT

Neither half is the workflow

SKILL, NO MCP

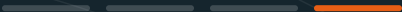


MCP, NO SKILL



PART 04

Lessons from shipping



Which one should we ship?

Skills



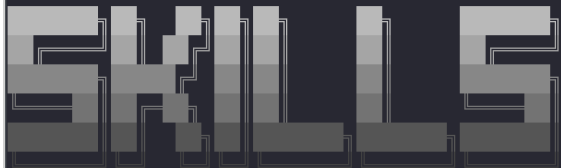
MCP Server

LESSON ①

Let your users choose the surface

Apollo Skills

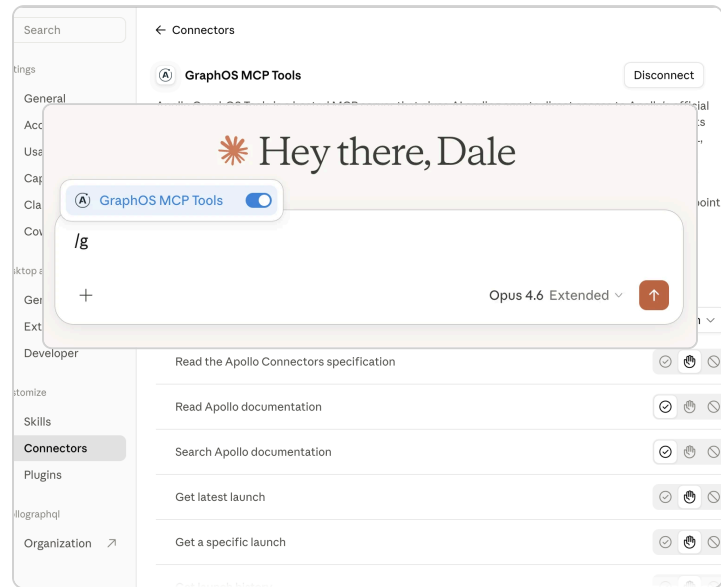
```
> npx skills add apollographql/skills
```



```
◇ Found 14 skills  
◆ Select skills to install  
Search:   
↑↓ move, space select, enter confirm
```

- ```
> ○ apollo-client
○ apollo-connectors
○ apollo-federation
○ apollo-ios
○ apollo-kotlin
○ apollo-mcp-server
```

### GraphOS MCP Server



# Does everything need a skill?

**CLI** **OSS** **Product** **API** **MCP**



## LESSON ②

# No delta, no skill

### Rover CLI

new + changed commands

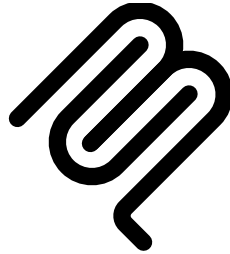
most commands are already trained

### GraphOS MCP Server

covered by its own tool descriptions,  
prompts, instructions

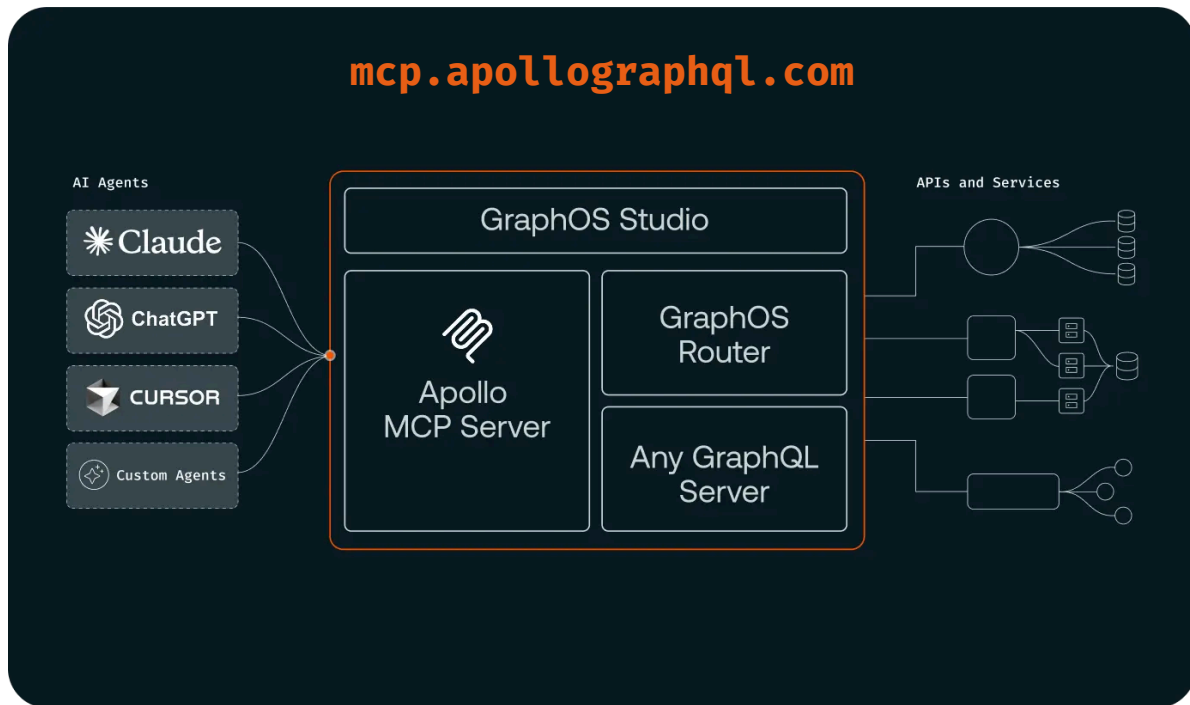
# Where should the MCP server run?

local?



remote?

# Ship a URL, not a binary



# How can we save context?

What do you mean  
you're out of tokens?



# Every tool is a bill

## separate servers

[docs.mcp.cloudflare.com](https://docs.mcp.cloudflare.com)

`search_docs`

`read_docs_page`

`migration_guide`

[radar.mcp.cloudflare.com](https://radar.mcp.cloudflare.com)

`get_url_scan`

`get_ip_details`

`list_asns`

`get_domain_ranking`

`get_traffic_trends`

## toolsets by audience

[mcp.apollographql.com](https://mcp.apollographql.com)

schema – loaded

`get_latest_launch`

`get_launch_log`

`get_lint_results`

`check_schema`

`get_subgraph_sdl`

insights – not loaded

`get_top_operations`

`get_op_metrics`

`get_subgraph_metrics`

`get_error_rates`

# Who should write the Skills?

users?



vendors?

# Publish the foundation

Personal Skills

Team Skills

Organization Skills

## apollographql/skills

📦 14 skills 📈 40.3K total installs 🌐 GitHub

```
$ npx skills add apollographql/skills
```



Command

🌟 Prompt

I love both!

MCP



Skills



Agent



Q & A

# Questions?

---

Dale Seo · Apollo GraphQL

 [github.com/DaleSeo](https://github.com/DaleSeo)

 [linkedin.com/in/daleseo](https://linkedin.com/in/daleseo)

 [x.com/DaleSeo](https://x.com/DaleSeo)



Rate this talk

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